DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

What Were the Trees of Eden?

Daat Tevunot §126

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §126 (end of the first part, on lowliness) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 11 May 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap

The class continued on page 320, in the middle of §126. We have been discussing the interconnected system of cogs: a person's effect on it depends on who he is, what he is doing and the quality of the action. We also discussed Adam HaRishon before and after the sin, and how his effect depended on his level. Now the Ramhal draws this together.

Two things that reflect a person's level

Before the sin, Adam was on a very high level in two ways:

1. **The effect of his actions.** What he did reached the highest places in the system, as discussed.
2. **His body.** His physical form reflected his spiritual level. The refinement of his body was almost like that of the angels.

That is why he could live in Eden. The Rabbi explained why the place where souls go after death is called Gan Eden: there is a connection between that Gan Eden and the Eden where Adam lived. How could a physical Adam be in Eden? Because before the sin he was a different kind of Adam. He had a body, flesh and blood, but an elevated one. It was not the final, complete body of Olam Haba, but it was fitting for Eden. Today, Gan Eden is "the waiting room" for souls until the world to come.

Garments of light

The Midrash says that in the Torah of Rabbi Meir it was written not "kotnot or" with an ayin, garments of skin, but "kotnot or" with an aleph, garments of light. Adam was surrounded by light. The Ramhal says this hints at the refinement of the body before the sin. After the sin it became heavy, as it is today.

The Rabbi warned against confusing this with Olam Haba. In Olam Haba there is a body, but no desire to eat, drink or procreate. Adam before the sin did have these desires, but his body leaned far more towards the spiritual.

Even after the sin, we have a glimpse of that level in Hanokh and Eliyahu, who refined themselves almost to the level of angels. The Torah tells us that they did not have a normal death and burial; they vanished, a kind of spiritual death. That was the level of Adam before the sin.

Was the fruit real?

Since Eden is now entirely spiritual, a place of souls, the Ramhal asks: what was the fruit Adam ate? The Gemara gives several opinions on what the fruit of the tree of knowledge was, among them grapes and the etrog. Whatever it was, do not picture the apples and grapes we know. The fruit was very fine.

He gave the example of air and earth. Air is physical, a scientific compound, yet relative to earth it is refined, almost spiritual. So too the fruit of Eden was physical, but like air compared to our fruit. And the eating was not in a heavy, coarse body as today, but in a refined, almost spiritual one, as with Eliyahu and Hanokh. The surroundings of a person match the effect of his deeds: before the sin, everything was refined; after the sin man's effect became limited, and everything became heavier and thicker.

The Rabbi added a striking thought: what was physical for Adam then is like what is spiritual for us now. When we have a spiritual experience on Shabbat or Yom Kippur, in Torah or tefillah, that is what ordinary life was for Adam before the sin. "Then begin to imagine what was his spiritual level before the sin." And imagine what level A, had he not sinned, would have been.

A participant said that in this world we can at most reach Adam's physical level, and that is why we need death, to take us from C to B, and then Olam Haba from B to A. The Rabbi agreed.

Was the sin inevitable?

A participant mentioned a view that the sin was inevitable, since the Torah had already spoken of death and sin, and that through it we reach a higher level. The Rabbi respectfully disagreed. That is a Hasidic way of thinking, that sin was inevitable and that one must see good in sin. "I don't subscribe to that philosophy, and it's not the Ramhal's philosophy."

The two trees

On page 324 the Ramhal turns to the tree of life and the tree of knowledge. He does not deny the plain meaning of the verses. Some people say it was all an analogy; the Ramhal does not say that. There was a real tree, real fruit and real eating, but of a kind hard for us to imagine, since we picture only physical texture and colour.

A participant gave the example of the manna, and the Rabbi called it excellent. The manna looked like a coriander seed and had taste, yet the people called it "lehem haklokel", light bread. It could taste of meat, but without any of the heaviness of eating meat. The fruit of Eden was something like that, and even higher.

Just as physical fruits can be used for medicine and healing, these refined fruits had powers. The tree of life would bring a person to closeness and love of God and free him from his physical nature. The tree of knowledge did the opposite, bringing sin into a person. Had Adam

eaten from the tree of life and not the tree of knowledge, he would immediately have risen in holiness. Instead he ate from the tree of knowledge, became heavy and material, lost the grandeur of his spiritual level, and became subject to death until he is atoned.

The Rabbi compared this to the Halacha of lashes: once a person has received his punishment, he is "your brother" again, and everything he did is forgotten. So too, once we pass through this world, we return to the original level, and can then reach level A: from C to B, and from B to A.

What comes next

This completes the first kind of ra, the lowliness and debasement in the physical. Next, the second kind: that everything physical must come to an end. There was no class the following week.

Summary

- Before the sin, Adam's deeds reached the highest levels, and his body matched that, refined almost like an angel's; this is why he could live in Eden.
- His "garments of light" became "garments of skin" after the sin, when the body became heavy.
- The fruit of Eden was real but refined, like air compared to earth, or like the manna; Hanokh and Eliyahu show a glimpse of that level.
- The Rabbi rejected the view that the sin was inevitable; it is not the Ramhal's approach.
- The tree of life would have raised Adam in holiness; eating from the tree of knowledge made him material and mortal, and our path is back from C to B to A.

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